Engage Community Agent

Research Report

Feb 2026 I Mukuta Das

Design: Ravier Souza

PM: Anna Pope, Kaleem Rahman, Irewole Akande

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Background

The Community Agent is designed to save time, improve trusted knowledge sharing, reduce unanswered questions, and help communities thrive with less effort. As this capability rolls out to GA, it is critical to understand how community managers/ experts are experiencing the agent in real communities: what they value, where they struggle, and why some who have access may not use it.

There is also a need to deep dive to understand the high rate of answers pending action for the private preview customers who have the agent activated. This research was conducted to understand this.

Research Objective

- Understand how community managers/ experts are currently experiencing the Community Agent across different communities, including typical scenarios such as answering questions, sharing resources, and keeping conversations active.
- Uncover key usability, trust, and transparency issues when interacting with the agent.
- Understand the main reasons for high pending and dismissal rates in the Community Agent approval workflow, including specific examples of user decision-making

Study Plan

Methodology

- In depth interviews
- 7 participants
- Recruited via through Engage Customer Connection Community, Sign up outreach in various platforms, Cold emailing & Respondent.io

Materials

- Live code was used by participants in some sessions.

Contributors

Research: Mukuta Das

Design: Ravier Souza

PM: Anna Pope, Kaleem Rahman, Irewole Akanda

Participants we learnt from

Company:

- Domino's Pizza Enterprise - 12 markets, 6,000+ support team members
- EY (Ernst & Young)- 400,000+ employees globally, learning programs
- COWI- Professional communities, technical focus
- Lloyd's Banking Group - UK banking, highly regulated environment
- Cognizant- Banking/financial services IT provider, 50-member team

User role:

Global Human & AI Knowledge Manager, Global Learning Programs Manager, Architect for Application Solutions, Lead Engineer, Customer Journey Manager, Product Owner, Service Delivery Manager & Solution Architect

Engage user role:

Community Managers & Network Admins

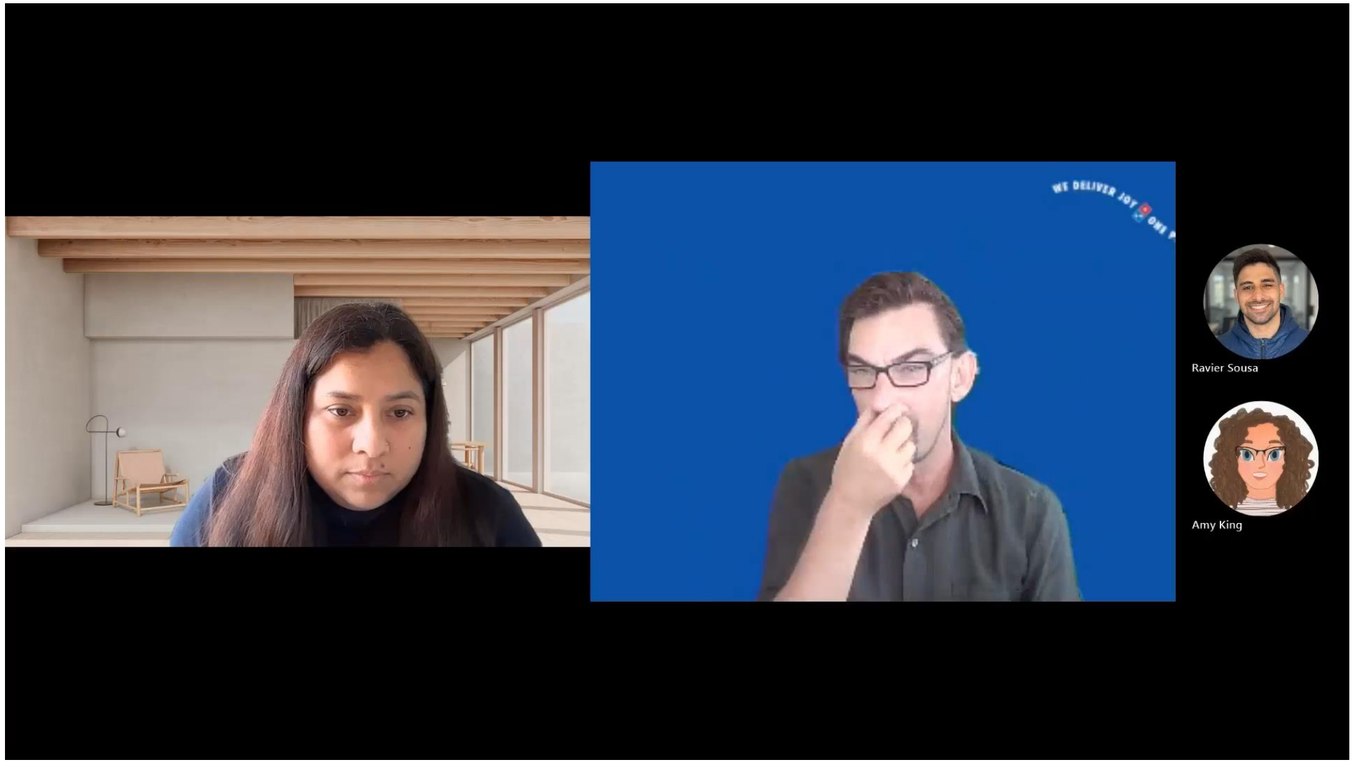
Success story

Success story of Domino’s Pizza Enterprise adopting Community Agent.

"***I used to get about on average 5 copilot Inquiries per day. I'm lucky if I get one per week*** *now because the questions and the knowledge is going through the community agent. In terms of challenges or concerns around the agent, I don't have any at this point in time, because particularly if I just think about my copilot community, the knowledge in there, I know what goes inside there, I know what data is in there, so* ***I know what stuff is going to be surfaced via that agent****.*"

— **Global Human and Artificial Intelligence Knowledge Manager, Domino's Pizza Enterprise**

Success Story: Domino's Pizza Enterprise



Strategic Deflection
Deflected inquiries from single-person bottleneck to scalable community knowledge. Enabled the agent across 4+ communities.

Knowledge Curation

Maintained curated knowledge center. Controlled source material ensures accurate, validated responses.

Visible Improvement

Workforce sees agent growth over time. Crisper answers, better formatting, growing trust.

Cultural Alignment

Tech-forward org with AI mandate. Workforce pre-trained on AI benefits and limitations.

*"We're **getting crisper answers**, we're getting spaces between paragraphs... **people are able to see that growth** and that change."* - Domino's Pizza Enterprise

Benefits of community agent

Users foresee a clear value of the community agent with a potential to scale in future.

Scalability Vision

Despite challenges, all users recognize clear value and are eager to adopt once blockers are resolved.

"This agent is really exciting *to us because it helps us to serve our learning customers better,* ***answer their queries better, to complete their badge****, to get it awarded, maybe start a second one, a third one, a fourth one. That kind of scalability piece is what your agent is going to help us with the most." Global Learning Programs Manager, EY*

Solves the problem of answering repetitive questions

Users appreciate the ability to save time by agent responding to repetitive questions.

"We tend to see a lot of repetitive questions that come through. They're phrased slightly differently, but the basic kind of top 10 queries that we get are fairly standard and very repetitive. ***Answering these very repetitive queries has such a huge productivity drain, energy drain, time consuming drain."*** *Global Learning Programs Manager, EY*

Multiple use cases were shared by users, highlighting potential of usage

- Payroll support communities (past transformation)
- Halifax hub facilities questions (ongoing)
- System transformation support (future)
- Social communities (runner's club, etc.)

"When we did payroll transformation, we set up a Viva Community for support... 99% of questions were about the payslip. ***It would have been absolutely amazing for us because once we answered one question, it would have just repeated the same thing****, that would have just saved a lot of time." Product Owner, Interchange 2.0, Lloyd's Banking Group*

Blockers for adoption for the community agent

Key challenges for adoption

Governance and control

- Deployment challenges
- Need for multi layers approvals

Trust and accuracy

- Source attribution
- Answer quality

Usability and UX

- Response latency
- Visibility & discovery

Experience and context

- Community voice & tone
- Interactive verification

“All or nothing” deployment is a critical adoption blocker.

Some organizations shared they cannot enable Community Agent for specific kind of communities.

- Enabling for all communities / large sized communities is considered risky. For e.g, Llyod Banking Group & COWI shared that it would be highly risky to enable to the agent in professional communities, communities with branch networks and customers as they fear agent may share customer private information.
- For another participant (Ernst and Young) the concern is higher for communities at global level with large number of community members (4000k+)

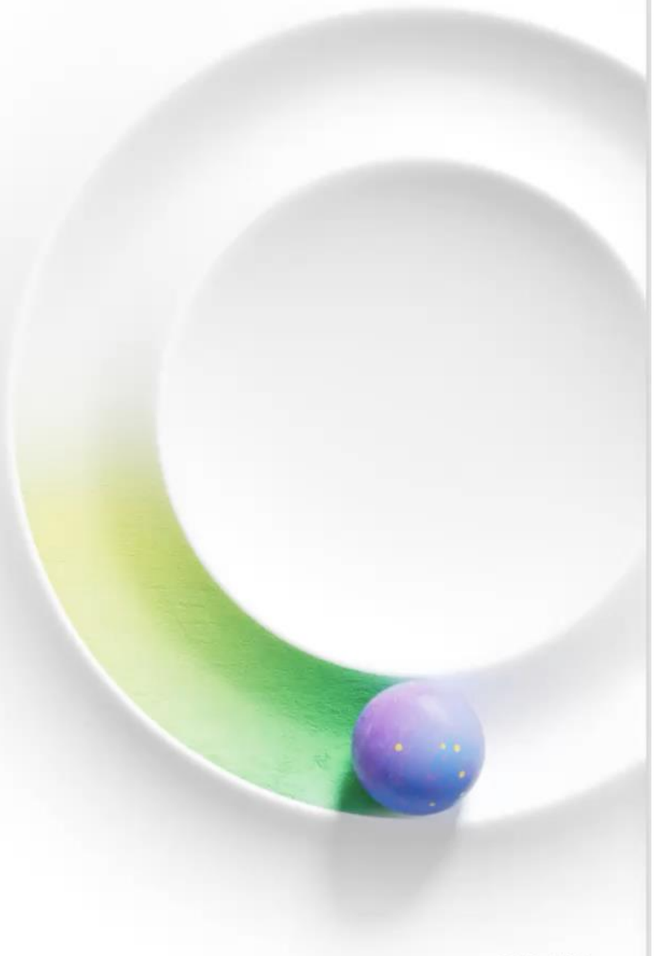
*"At the moment, **once it's on, it's on for everybody and there's no way I can control that at a granular level**... I'm just turning it on for the world. If we could limit its availability to a certain set of key communities that we trust to trial it in a live environment that would be beneficial... identify where they are and what the risk would be of rolling it out"* Engage Admin, Lead Engineer, Lloyd's Banking Group

*"There's **one main thing we don't like and why we're not doing it. It's either all or none**. We would be testing it in production on specific communities, but we can only enable it or not for all network... We cannot be sure that others will not start also using them."* Community Manager, Architect for Application Solutions, COWI

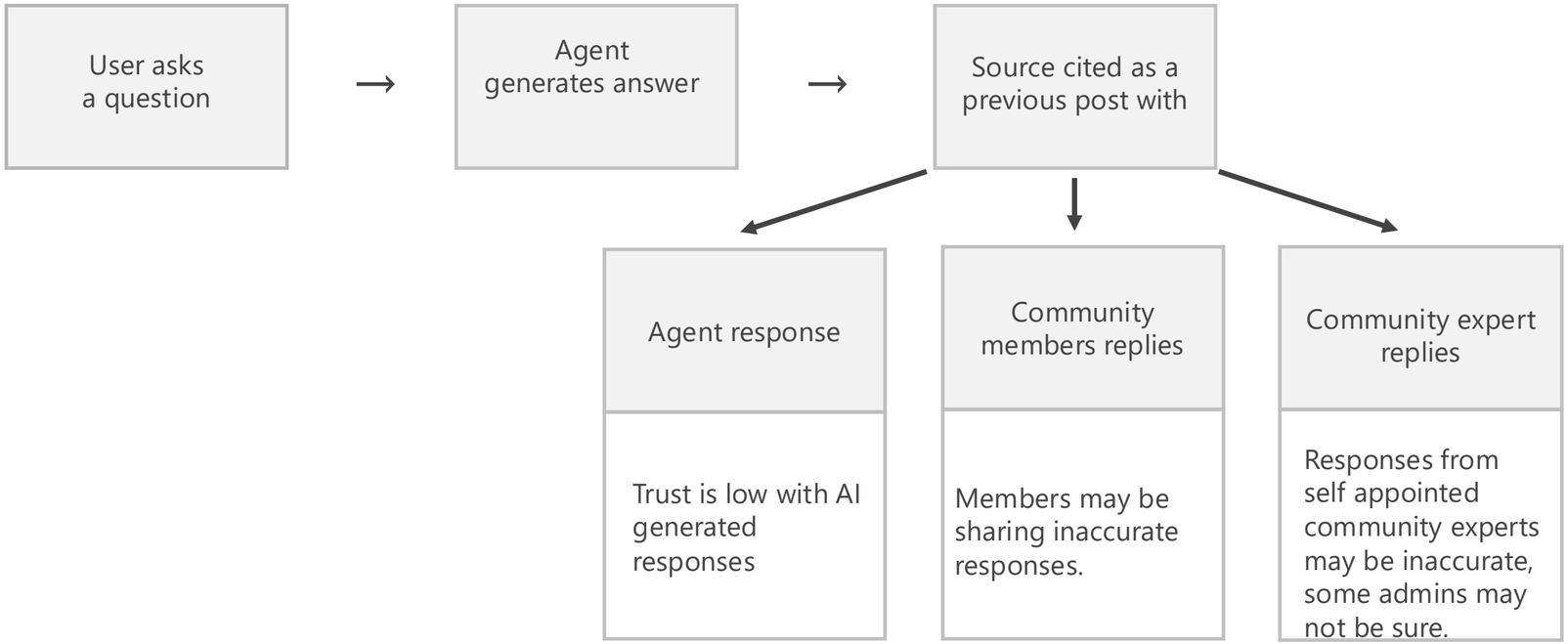
Recommendation: Consider providing admins with the option to enable Community Agent selectively—for specific communities or trial groups—so they can safely pilot in trusted environments before broader rollout. Granular controls would reduce perceived risk, unblock experimentation, and accelerate adoption by letting organizations prove value incrementally

Source attribution challenge

Source attribution challenge



Unreliable source attribution breaks trust, impacting adoption.



Impact:

- Difficult to trace back to actual source of truth
- This is resulting in trust deficit for community managers, admins and experts.
- Creates adoption blocker as one of the community admin stopped using the agent entirely.

*"It just goes to another post posted from agent... **agent's reply is not a source of truth. It can be the dream it had,** because sometimes AI dreams."* Architect, COWI

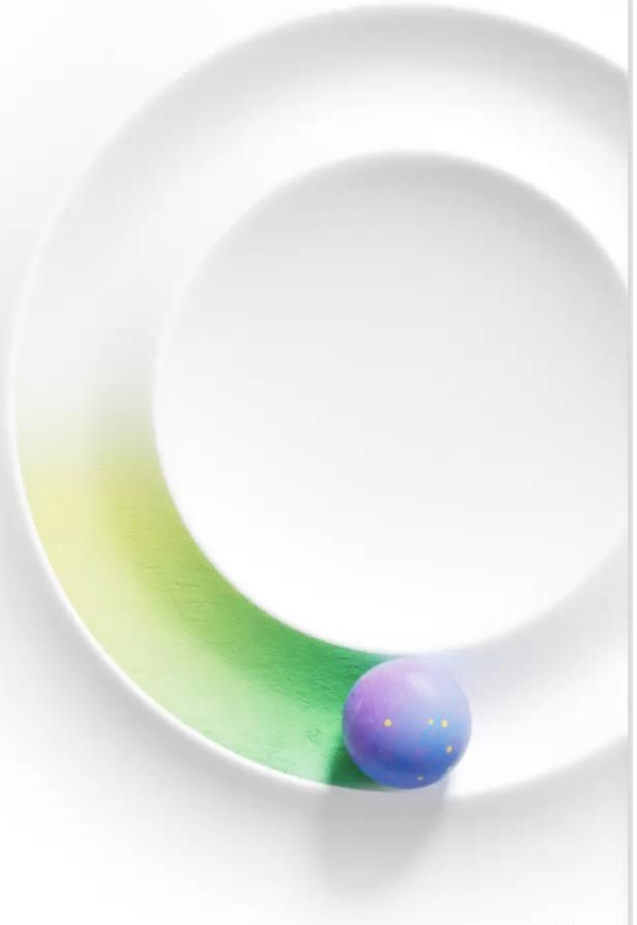
*"Some of the **answers it gave were way off the mark**... if that had just been auto published, somebody may have taken that as the truth."* Lead Engineer, Lloyd's Banking Group

*"**None of these answers are from a community expert.** So, there's a high probability that this isn't correct information."* Global Learning Programs Manager, EY

Recommendation: It is critical to help admins by making sure that attribution is explicit, verifiable and anchored to an authoritative content. This would reduce trust deficits, prevent misinformation from compounding, and remove a key blocker.
Sharepoint integration may address this blocker.

Answer quality time paradox

Answer quality challenge



Agent's answer paradox is that it's adding more time to edit.

Community admins, managers, experts at this stage are choosing to manually verify all the agent responses which add to their time spent, negating the ideal benefit of time saving by using the agent.

Answer quality resulted in a variety of challenges which were not aligning with user expectations:

Too comprehensive	Questionable references	Wrong tone	Stale information
Lengthy when users want concise	Unvalidated posts, not official guides	Formal bullets vs. conversational style	Outdated posts over current FAQs

Using the agent resulted in
- Admin spends time editing each response
- Some admins found it quicker to dismiss and write from scratch
- Admins are also habituated to write the answers in the main feed directly.

Alternately if the admin knows the answer, they directly go to the community feed, write the answer in a tone which is aligned with community culture, accurate (with an ability to add official internal and external sources). Compared to the time taken to review the agent response, this workflow is done much faster.

*"It's almost **quicker just to write the answer from scratch** ourselves."*
Global learning program manager, EY

Recommendation: It may be helpful to improve default answer quality to be concise, current (not outdated) and community aligned to reduce manual editing time, addressing the paradox of reviewing taking more time vs answering from scratch.

Agent generated inconsistent way of presenting links

Site investigation and geotechnical interpretation agent AI generated Drafted Sat at 7:09 AM

Here are examples of presentation files stored in this community's SharePoint space. These show the types of presentations that are currently available:

- Introduction to geology and geophysics: https://cowiprep.sharepoint.com/sites/c010133-community/_layouts/15/Doc.aspx?sourcedoc=%7B74324806-B4ED-43BB-9FB6-86554E258CE1%7D&file=Introduction%20Geology%20and%20Geophysics.pptx&action=edit&mobileredirect=true&EntityRepresentationId=47b9622f-0d87-4c09-b68c-f8372ba31fda
- Introduction to geology and geophysics (alternate link): https://cowiprep.sharepoint.com/sites/c010133-community/_layouts/15/Doc.aspx?sourcedoc=%7B74324806-B4ED-43BB-9FB6-86554E258CE1%7D&file=Introduction%20Geology%20and%20Geophysics.pptx&action=edit&mobileredirect=true&DefaultItemOpen=1
- Feb '18 presentation: https://cowiprep.sharepoint.com/sites/c010133-community/_layouts/15/Doc.aspx?sourcedoc=%7B18CAF871-906C-41AA-918F-9282ECF38920%7D&file=Feb%20%2718%20presentation%20%28final%29.pptx&action=edit&mobileredirect=true&DefaultItemOpen=1
- One slide summary presentation: https://cowiprep.sharepoint.com/sites/c010133-community/_layouts/15/Doc.aspx?sourcedoc=%7B6BC2ADA3-5344-4742-94B2-58ECF4F9F59C%7D&file=20250929_1-slide_presenation.pptx&action=edit&mobileredirect=true&DefaultItemOpen=1

M365 Copilot agent AI generated Drafted 53m ago

You can only open the Prompt Gallery from inside a Copilot chat pane, regardless of whether you're in Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Teams, or a browser. There is no standalone Prompt Gallery button in the Office ribbon.

You can reach it anywhere that gives you the full Copilot sidebar. Once that sidebar is open, select View prompts. This is shown in the recording in the enablement materials at What's New & Next for Microsoft 365 Copilot . Americas-Friendly-2024-12-03T18.00.20.0000000Z.mp4. The Copilot app inside Teams gives the most consistent entry point, and the browser version works the same way. You can also install it as a progressive web app for one-click access.

You cannot open saved prompts directly in Word, Excel, or PowerPoint without first opening the Copilot chat pane. Community posts, including one by Stephanie Boyadjian, point out that saved prompts do not appear in in-app gallery surfaces [1]. Some users also see the Prompt Gallery link in Teams disappear, as described by Jeff Merrifield, and those issues sometimes require support escalation [2].

Site investigation and geotechnical interpretation agent AI generated Drafted Jan 28

Short Version: There are eight posts in this community.

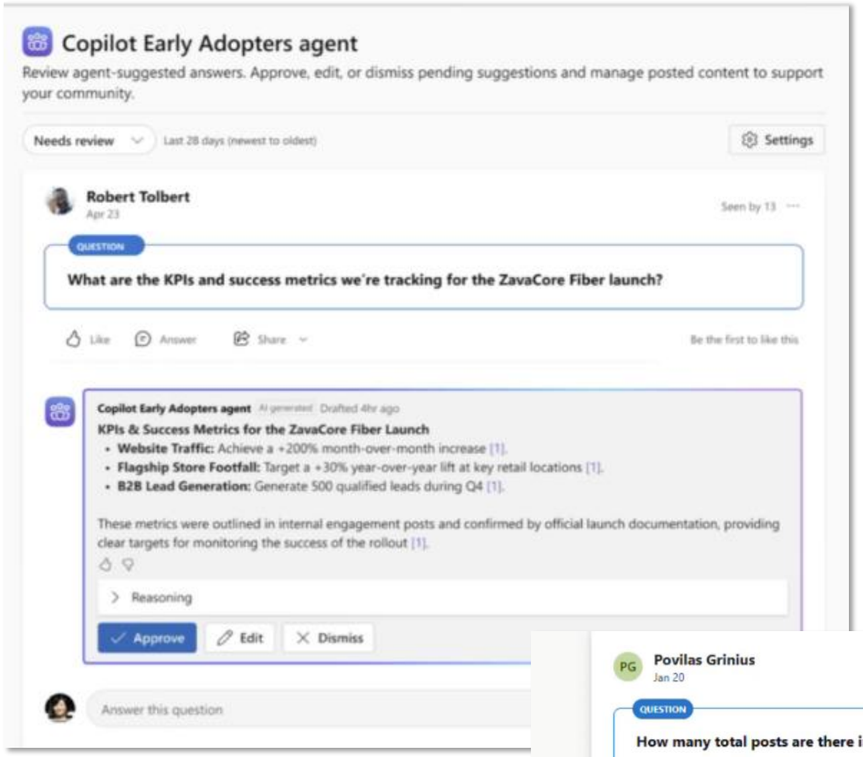
There are eight posts in this community, based on the activity data you shared[1][2][3][4][5][6][7][8]. That number comes directly from the posts listed in that dataset.

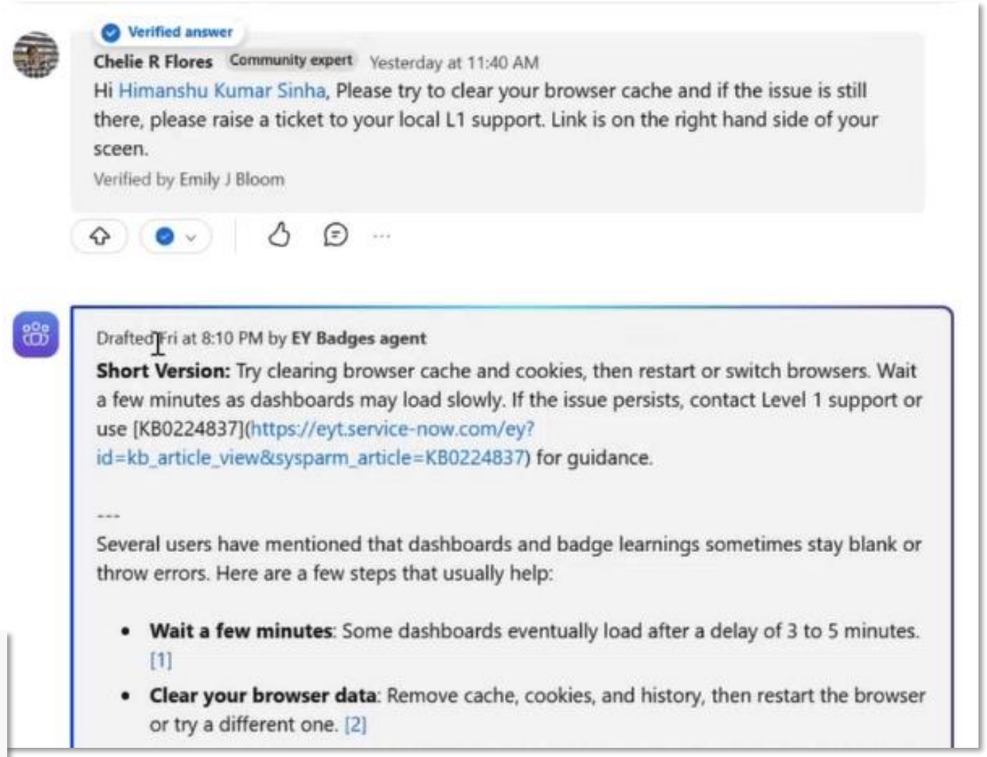
https://enga

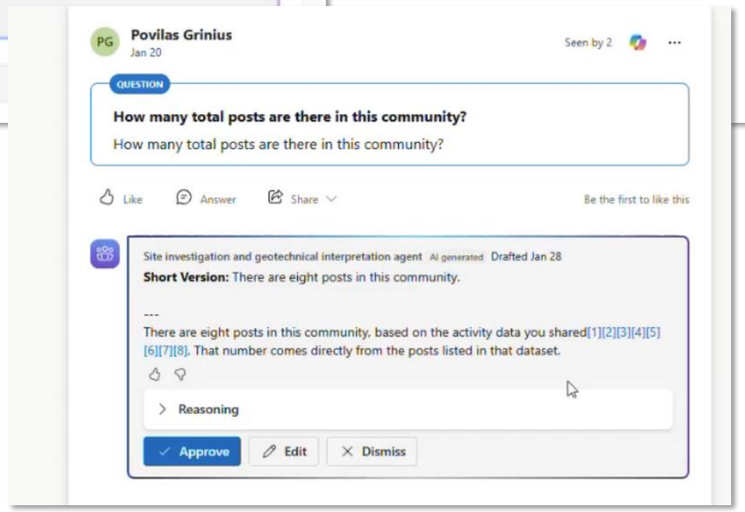
Reasoning

Approve Edit Dismiss

Some more examples of variety in presenting answers







Clarity in content appreciated in these agent answers.

Short and long version repeating similar content. Tone of community expert's answer is casual. Agent response is formal with bullets.

Multi layer approval expected to ensure agent response is accurate

For some participants (Cognizant, Llyods Banking group & EY), having only single-layer approval is insufficient.

They shared they **need configurable chains of approval, especially for technical questions**.

The expectations is to have a subject matter expert to review the answer and then the community admin approves the final answer. This will help in a better auditing trail, especially in the trialing phase.

*"As a community admin I wouldn't want to switch the agent on and let it automatically answer questions**, I'd want to vet them first, make sure it come back with a reasonable set of answers or a reasonable answer that made sense.**.. And then post those as a verified admin would review it."*

Lead Engineer, Lloyd's Banking Group

Unclear response time for the agent reduces user's confidence in it.

Response latency challenge

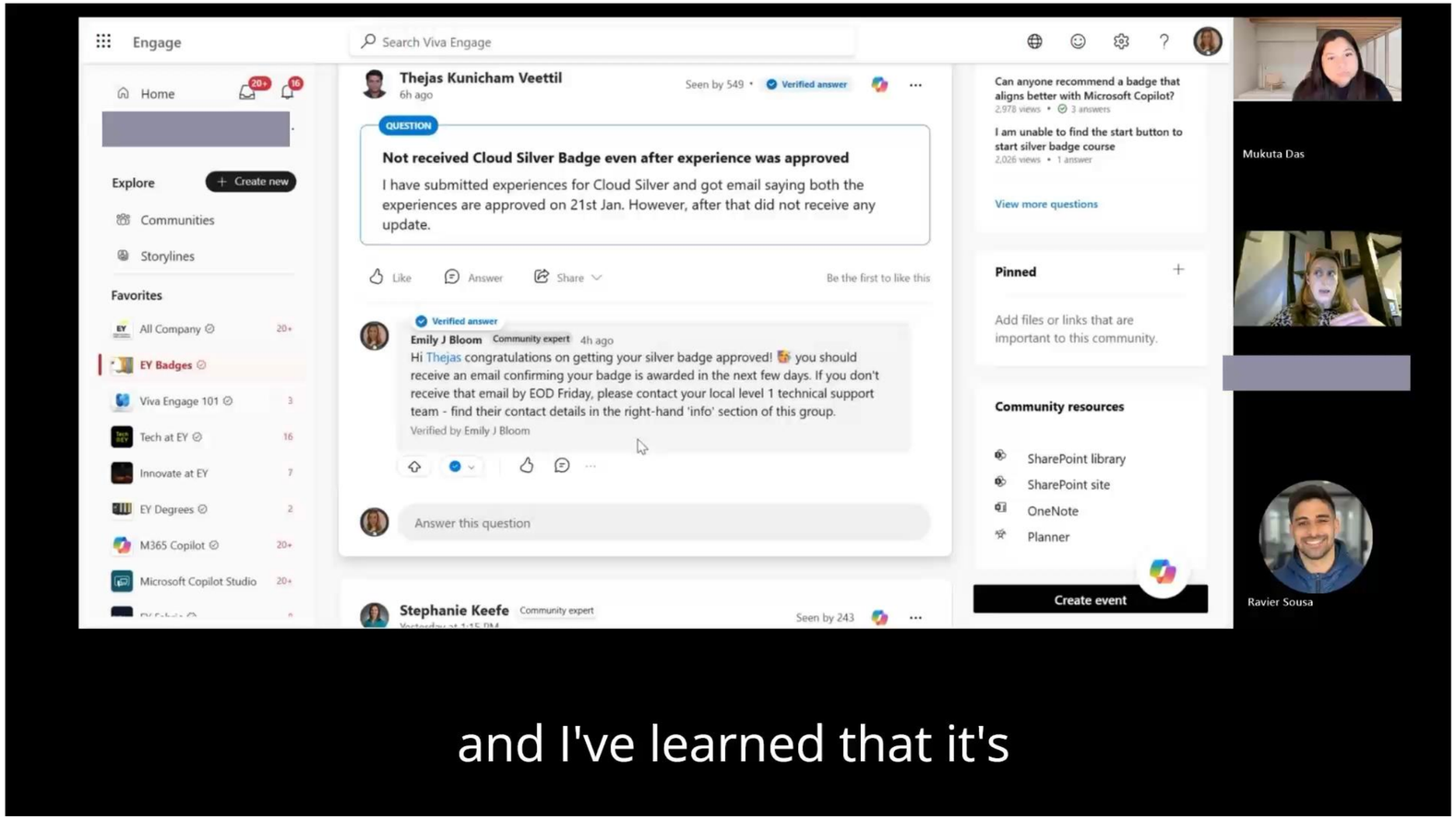
For a few users, the agent was not responding to questions as early as they expected it to. In one incident, the agent took more than 8 days to respond.

Users shared expectations to show:

- **Status Indicators** such as agent is processing, agent completed review, agent cannot answer.
- Clear **expectation of when answer will be available**
- Email notification when answer ready for approval

*"I would **like to know if the agent already read this** and decided that it doesn't have an answer or didn't proceed to check it and might come up with an answer later. **There's no indication for me as an owner; do you know answer to it or and I should just wait and you will help me** or I should try going to library and doing something myself." COWI*

Frictions in workflow creates barriers to use the agent.



The agent's **draft is easy to miss because it does not appear in the main feed**.

- As a result, community managers often skip it and respond manually instead.

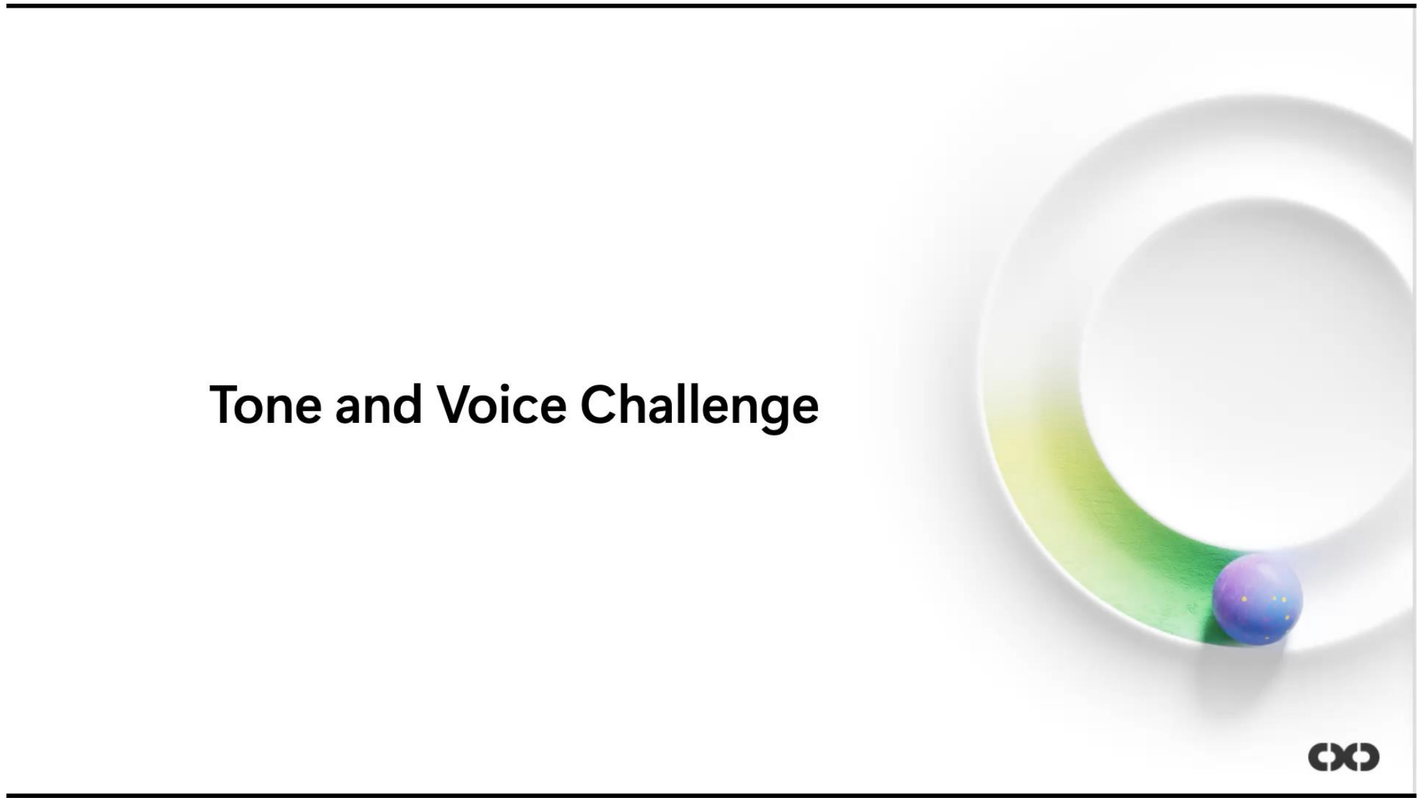
Reviewing the agent's suggestion requires extra navigation outside the core workflow.

- This added effort makes it less likely that admins to go a separate page.

Users expect the system to recognize if questions are answered by admins and automatically remove or dismiss the unused draft.

Recommendation: Current in feed review UX changes will address this concern.

Agent's voice and tone currently is not aligning with user expectations.



Agent uses generic, formal tone that doesn't match specific community cultures.

Users expect the ability of:

- Custom instructions per community to define tone
- Training on community-specific terminology and culture
- Option to provide style guide or example responses
- Define personality (formal vs. casual, technical vs. accessible)

*"The learning experience for us is so important. I think one of the key value propositions of our EY Badges program is the support that we provide our learners, that recognition, that celebration, **using celebratory, encouraging language, understanding, helpful**."*
Global Learning Programs Manager, EY

Recommendation: Consider exploring the option to support admins with community-level controls (for example: tone presets, example responses, or lightweight custom instructions) so the Community Agent can align with how each community communicates. Supporting variation in formality, verbosity, and style would reduce the need for manual rewrites, increase confidence in publishing agent responses, and make the agent feel like a natural participant rather than a generic system voice.

Clarifying agent response before posting would increase confidence.

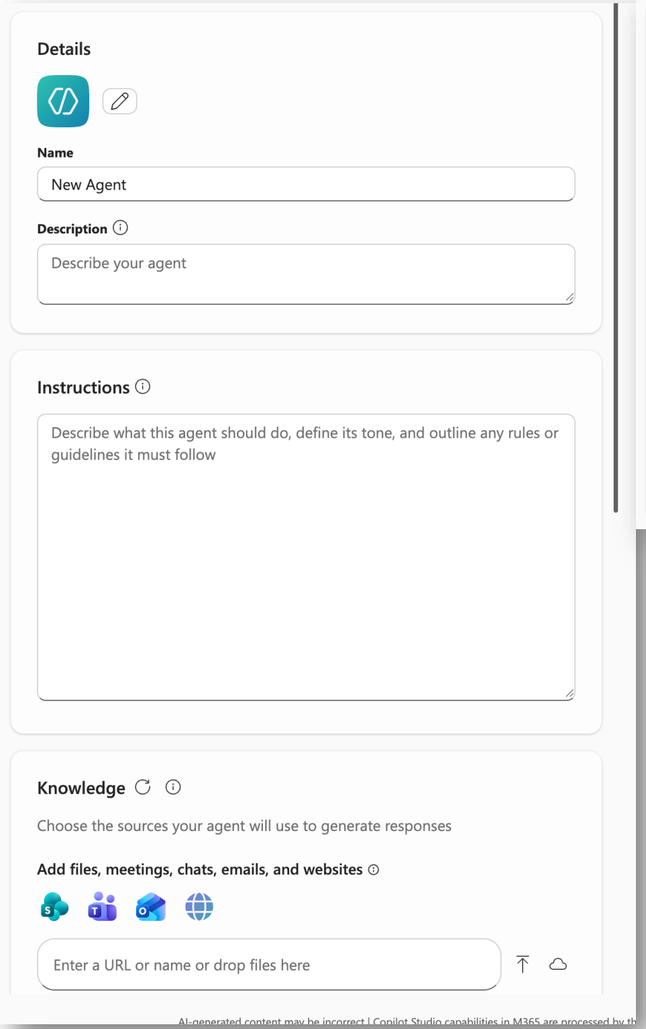
One participant shared an expectation to **have the capability to interact with the agent in the review stage,** conducting a pre-approval interrogation as this would help them feel more assured about the agent's answer accuracy. Some prompts suggestion shared were:

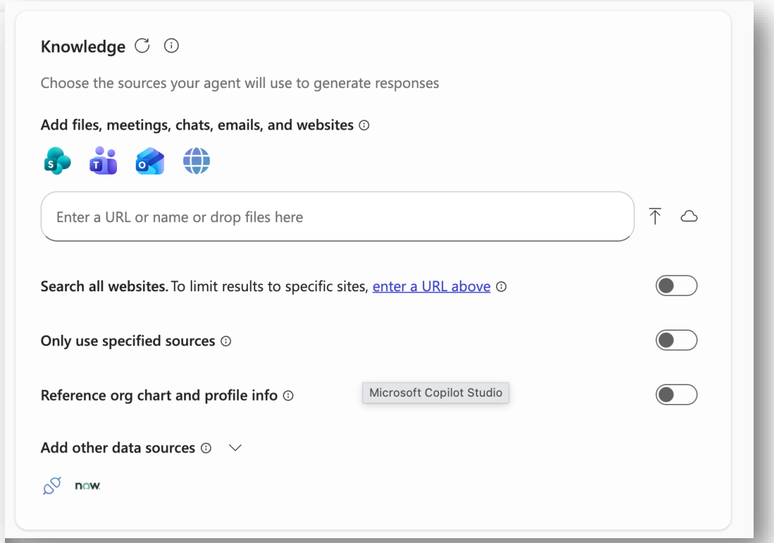
- "Why did you suggest this?" interrogation capability
- "What other approaches exist?" alternative generation
- "Show me the sources you used" transparency request

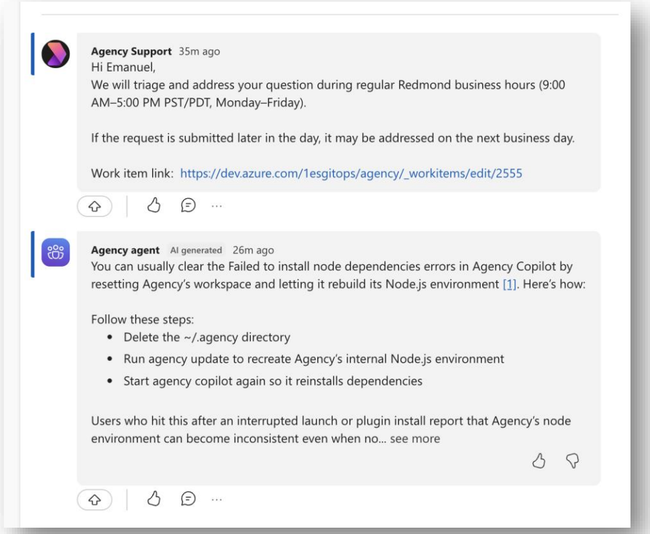
*"Allow me to ask something to that agent related to the topic. I would love to **ask a few questions before I go ahead and approve it (agent drafted answer)**."* Service Delivery Manager & Solution Architect, Cognizant

Recommendation: Consider exploring the ability for admins to interact with the agent at review stage to confirm on the answer accuracy.

Custom agent from MS Copilot Studios are being added in communities.





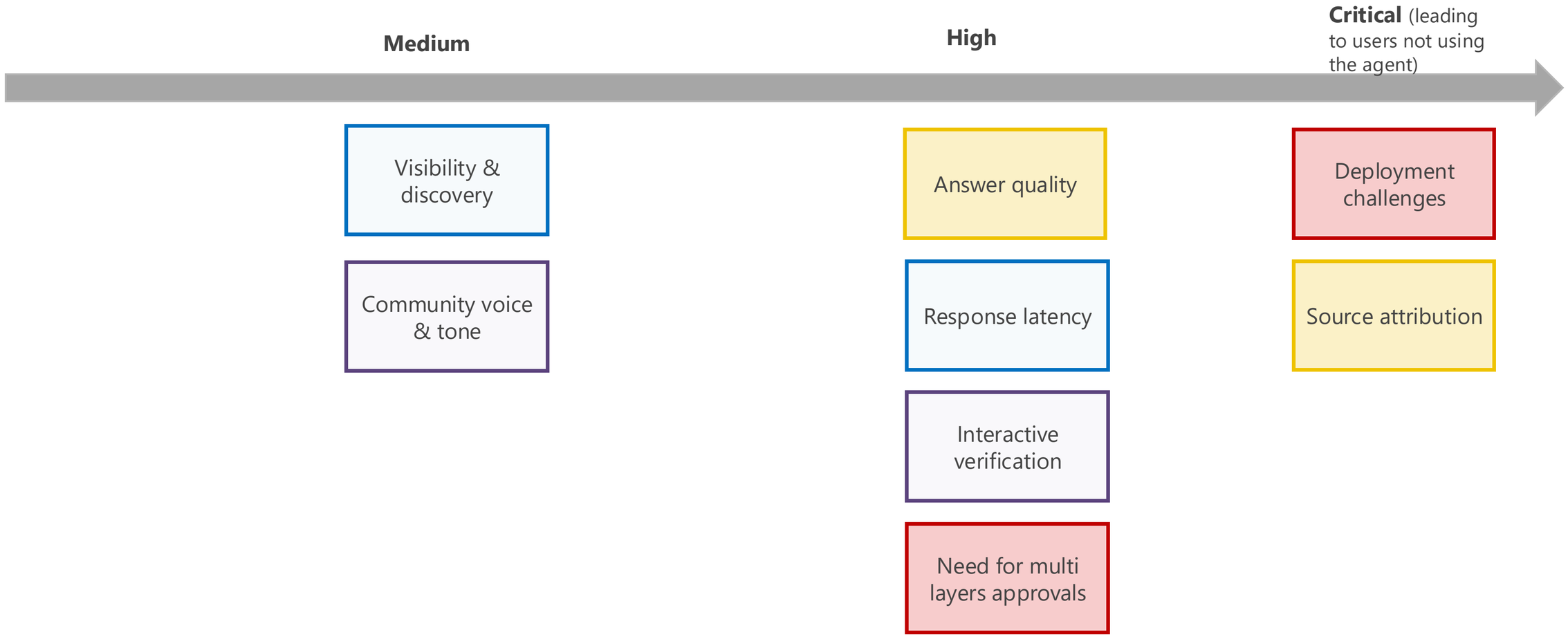


Agency community

EY shared that for one of the communities, they have added a custom knowledge agent, where they added SharePoint links, external knowledge sources and docs as data sources for the agent. The goal of these agent is also share information in the community.

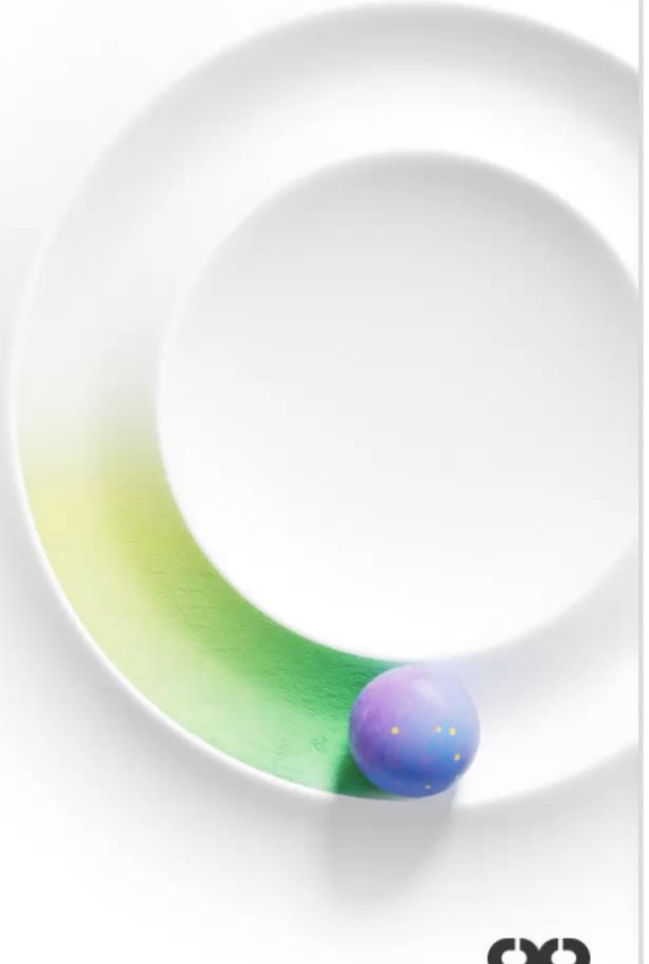
This may become a blocker for our community agent.

Mapping challenges based on severity



Let’s understand the journey and challenges in adopting the community agent.

Initial set up phase



There are gaps in the set up and initial usage stage that needs to be filled to make our users feel more confident to use the agent

Set up phase	Post set up initial phase	Usage phase	Successful adoption
Users required support with **documentation & training** to guide community managers to successfully launch and use.	Users are not confident of using the agent as **it's a new concept** & **trust is low** in the agent's accuracy level.	Users facing several concerns while using the agent: • Need to **check agent response accuracy (leading to higher time spent** by community managers). • UX issues (review needs to be done in a separate page, not in the flow). • Variance in tone of agent (not similar to community norms).	For Dominoes, adoption is close to being a success: • **Knowledge seeding and role modelling** done by the community manager. • They noticed the change in answer quality with formatting and length.

Recommendation: It would be helpful to provide clearer setup flows, role-based onboarding, and just-in-time guidance that help community managers understand how the agent works, what to expect from its responses, and how to successfully launch it in their communities. Supplementing this with practical documentation, readiness checklists, and early-stage best practices would make users feel supported during initial use, trust the agent's outputs and be more confident progressing from setup to sustained adoption

Customers we learnt from are at different stages of adoption

Apprehensive to adopt

Lloyd's Banking Group & Cognizant

- These customers have high regulatory requirements.
- They are risk-averse.
- They need documented guidance and proof of concept from others.
- They require multi-layer approval while reviewing the agent responses to confirm accuracy.

Requirement:
Granular control + multi-layer approval + validated sources

Ready to adopt but with conditions

EY, COWI

- For these customers, there is a clear need for the agent, and they want to scale and deflect.
- They have dedicated resources that would be critical to add to the agent (beyond the SharePoint library attached to the community).
- Current answer quality is adding time spent for the community managers while reviewing the agent responses.

Requirement:
Better answer quality + integration with additional knowledge sources

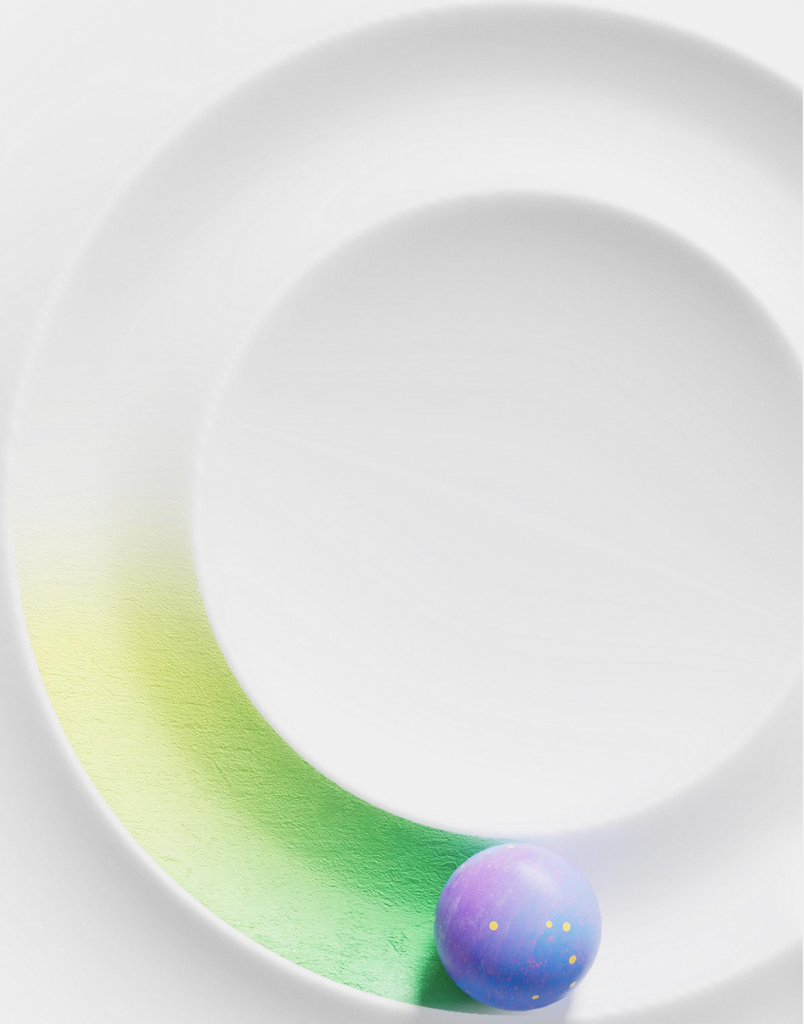
Successfully adopting

Dominoes

- Dominoes has a well managed curated, controlled knowledge base in the community.
- Community manager is highly invested in making the agent successful as it is helping in saving their time.

Requirement:
Better source attribution, consistent agent responsiveness

Recommendations & Next steps



Recommendations: Drive confident & scalable adoption

Enable granular deployment controls

- Allow admins to turn the agent on for specific communities rather than enforcing an all-or-nothing rollout. This reduces perceived risk and enables safe piloting in trusted spaces.

Strengthen source attribution to restore trust

- Ensure agent responses always cite original source documents or posts with replies by community manager/ experts, never the agent's own prior answers as it creates mistrust. Gaining trust in the agent is essential for adoption.

Support governed rollouts with configurable approval models

- Introduce multi-layer approval options (e.g., community expert review → admin approval) so organizations can meet compliance and auditing needs during early adoption stage.

Allow community-specific configuration

- Support admins to customize formatting style, tone per community, reflecting different cultures (technical vs. social, formal vs. conversational). Current one-size-fits-all may prevent scaling.

Provide adoption guidance and readiness materials

- Offer clear setup guidance, best practices, and pre-packaged announcement materials to help community managers confidently launch and explain the agent.

Recommendations: Reduce review backlogs & support faster approvals

Improve default answer quality to reduce editing effort

- Agent responses should be concise, current, and aligned to community tone, so admins don't feel it's faster to dismiss and rewrite from scratch.

Surface agent drafts directly in the main workflow

- Make agent-generated answers visible in the main feed instead of a separate review surface to prevent "out of sight, out of mind" behavior. **(Product is working on this already)**

Auto-resolve obsolete drafts

- If an admin has already answered a question manually, the system should automatically dismiss or deprioritize the agent draft to avoid wasted review time. **(Product is working on this already)**

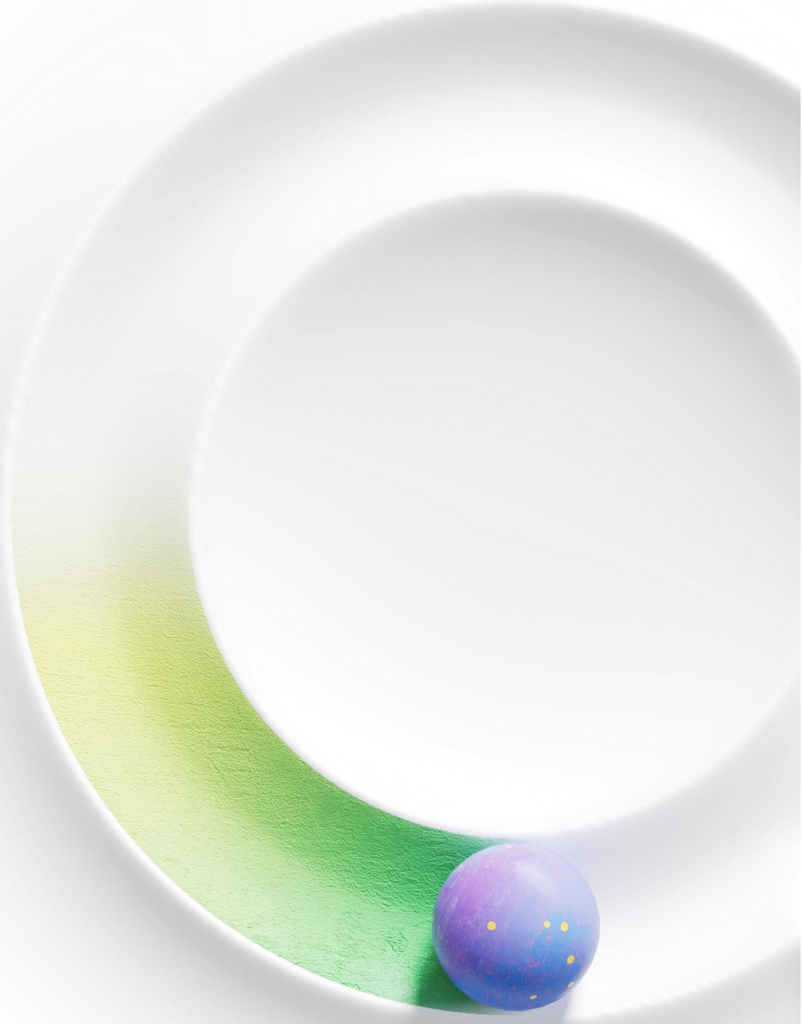
Introduce response status indicators

- Show whether the agent is processing, blocked, or unable to answer—so admins know when to wait versus intervene manually.

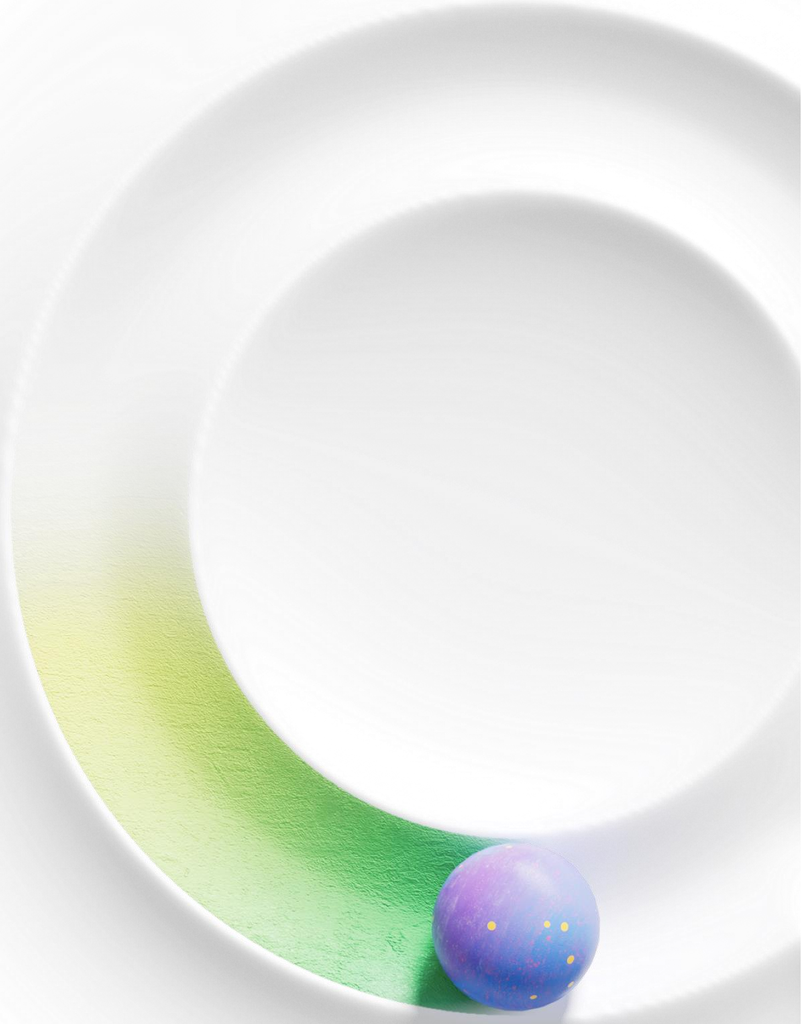
Add pre-approval interaction with the agent

- Allow reviewers to ask questions like "Why did you suggest this?" or "Show me your sources" before approving, increasing confidence and speeding decisions.

Thank you.



Appendix



Quotes

On the value proposition

*"This agent is really exciting to us... because it helps us to serve our learning customers better... That kind of scalability piece, I think, is what your agent is going to help us with the most." — **Emily J Bloom, Global Learning Programs Manager, EY***

*"We tend to see a lot of repetitive questions... For a small team, we're really focused on continuous improvement... answering these very repetitive queries has such a huge productivity drain, energy drain, time consuming drain." — **Emily J Bloom, EY***

On deployment control

*"The main showstopper was this all or nothing." — **Laima Kristole, Architect for Application Solutions, Azure Suite and Power Platform***

*"At the moment, once it's on, it's on for everybody and there's no way I can control that at a granular level down to those communities that I trust and the admins that I trust." — **Mark Wilson, Lead Engineer, Lloyd's Banking Group***

On source attribution

*"When I click on it, it just goes to another post posted from agent... Agent's reply is not a source of truth. It can be, it's the dream it had, because sometimes AI dreams." — **Laima Kristole, Azure Suite and Power Platform***

*"None of these answers are from a community expert. So there's a high probability that this isn't correct information." — **Emily J Bloom, EY***

On regulatory risk

*"If somebody switched it on in one of those communities, then people are, you know, people, members of the public are being given the wrong advice by an AI agent... which is a big concern." — **Mark Wilson, Lloyd's Banking Group***

*"Due to certain policies of the organization, of the banking system, of the enterprise, I cannot let that agent do that [autonomous production changes]." — **Shiladitya, Service Delivery Manager, Cognizant***

On success

*"I used to get about maybe on average 5 copilot Inquiries per day. I'm lucky if I get one per week now because the questions and the knowledge is going through the community." — **Bryan Williams, Global Human and Artificial Intelligence Knowledge Manager, Domino's Pizza Enterprise***

*"We're getting crisper answers, we're getting spaces between paragraphs... people are able to see that growth and that change, they know something's happening." — **Bryan Williams, Domino's Pizza Enterprise***

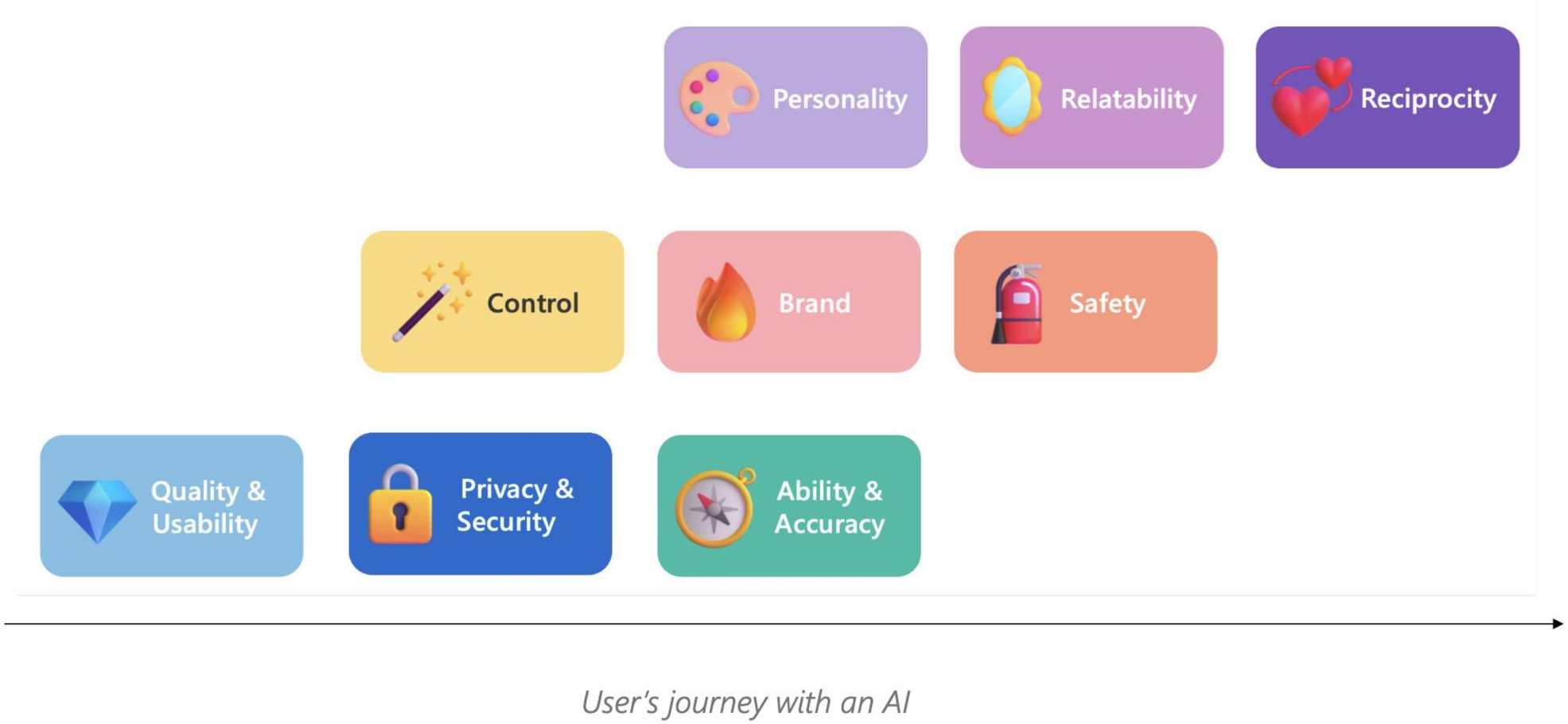
On future vision

*"When we did payroll transformation... 99% of them were about the payslip... It would have been absolutely amazing for us because once we answered one question, it would have just repeated the same thing... This would have just saved a lot of time." — **Sam Lunt, Product Owner, Lloyd's Banking Group***

Wishlist from EY

- *an on/off switch for if experts are allowed to approve posts*
- *an open text field in the agent settings to add any custom instructions about how the tone/behavior should be (example: "you are talking to non-technical users and not IT admins, be personable")*
- *just use the knowledge source picker from Agent Builder. Let us add sites but also attach documents, spreadsheets, point to lists, etc. FAQs are the most valuable asset and lots of people store those in SPO lists.*
- *pre-package announcement materials for community managers to use to announce what the agent does. Maybe put this on adoption.microsoft.com to help drive Community Agent adoption overall?*

9 Pillars of Trust



Pillars of Trust_Foundational UXR Findings from Copilot & Pi Power Users.pptx

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